

I WILL MAKE A NEW COVENANT

Jeremiah 31-32 and God's Promise Fulfilled in Jesus

Jeremiah 31:33-34

“I will put my law in their inward parts, and write it in their hearts; and will be their God, and they shall be my people.

... for I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more.”

Key lines from the King James Version (public domain).

A detailed biblical-theological study with close exegesis,
historical setting, scholarly viewpoints, and canonical fulfillment

Prepared August 2026

How to Read This Study

Central thesis

Jeremiah does not announce that God has abandoned his ancient purpose. He announces that God himself will overcome the covenant-breaking heart, forgive sin decisively, restore his people, and establish an enduring relationship. The New Testament identifies Jesus as the mediator whose blood inaugurates this promised covenant and the Spirit as the one who writes God's instruction on the heart.

This work is written from a historic Christian perspective while taking the Old Testament passage seriously in its own literary and Jewish setting. It begins with Jeremiah rather than importing conclusions into him, follows the promise through the other prophets, and then asks how Jesus and the apostles read the same promise.

The study also distinguishes what the text clearly says from questions on which Christian scholars disagree. Reformed covenant theologians, dispensational and progressive dispensational interpreters, and progressive covenantal or Reformed Baptist scholars all affirm that Jesus inaugurates the new covenant. They differ over the covenant community, the place of ethnic Israel and the land promises, baptism, and the degree to which Jeremiah 31 is already fulfilled or awaits a future completion. Those differences are presented without allowing the controversy to obscure the central claim shared by the New Testament: Jesus is the mediator of the better covenant promised through Jeremiah.

Scripture blocks use the King James Version because it is in the public domain. Discussion often explains Hebrew terms and uses modern wording for clarity. Bracketed source numbers point to the detailed source notes and bibliography at the end.

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Executive Overview: The Promise in One View

Promise in Jeremiah	Human problem answered	Fulfillment centered in Jesus
A “new covenant” (31:31)	The Sinai covenant was broken	Jesus declares “the new covenant in my blood” (Luke 22:20; 1 Cor. 11:25).
Torah written within (31:33)	Sin was engraved on the heart (Jer. 17:1)	The Spirit transforms the inner person (2 Cor. 3:3-6; Rom. 8:1-4).
“I will be their God” (31:33)	Covenant fellowship had been shattered	In Christ, God dwells with his people by the Spirit and brings them near.
All will know the LORD (31:34)	Many belonged outwardly while remaining faithless	New-covenant knowledge is personal, saving, and eventually universal among the redeemed.
Final forgiveness (31:34)	Repeated sacrifices testified that sin remained unresolved	Christ offers himself once for all (Heb. 9:11-15; 10:1-18).
One heart and one way (32:39)	The people repeatedly turned aside	God creates a persevering people who fear him for their good.
An everlasting covenant (32:40)	Earlier administrations could be violated and judged	Jesus is the mediator whose blood is “the blood of the everlasting covenant” (Heb. 13:20).
God rejoices to do good (32:41)	Exile looked like abandonment	Restoration flows from God’s whole-hearted delight and faithfulness.

The controlling observation

Jeremiah 31:31-34 is not an isolated slogan. It stands inside Jeremiah 30-33, a sustained “Book of Consolation” in which God promises return from exile, reunification of Israel and Judah, renewed fertility, a restored city, Davidic hope, worship, forgiveness, and a permanent work in the heart. Jeremiah 32 then restates the promise as an “everlasting covenant” and emphasizes divine preservation: God will put his fear within his people so that they will not turn away.

1. The Covenant Story Before Jeremiah

Jeremiah’s promise is new, but it is not disconnected from what came before. Scripture presents God’s redemptive purpose through a sequence of covenants. Each covenant adds definition to the same divine intention: God will have a people who live in his presence, bear his character, receive his blessing, and become the means by which blessing reaches the world. [3][5]

The word covenant describes a solemnly established relationship involving promises, obligations, signs, and sanctions. Biblical covenants are not contracts between equals. God sovereignly initiates them, yet he genuinely binds himself by his word. This makes the covenant theme one of the Bible’s chief ways of showing how the transcendent God commits himself to creatures in history.

From creation to Abraham

The opening chapters of Genesis establish the goal even before the word covenant becomes prominent: humanity is made in God's image, placed in sacred space, commissioned to fill and rule the earth, and invited to life under God's word. Human rebellion brings exile from Eden, curse, and death. Yet Genesis 3:15 plants a promise inside the judgment: the offspring of the woman will finally crush the serpent.

The covenant with Noah preserves the creation order so that redemption can unfold in history. The covenant with Abraham then concentrates the promise: offspring, land, blessing, kingship, and worldwide blessing through Abraham's seed (Gen. 12:1-3; 15; 17; 22:15-18). Jeremiah's new covenant cannot mean the abandonment of this promise, because Jeremiah expressly speaks of Israel and Judah, restoration to the land, and God's enduring commitment to the descendants of Israel (Jer. 31:31, 35-37; 32:37-44). Walter Kaiser therefore stresses continuity between the ancient promise and the new covenant, even while recognizing the new covenant's decisive advance. [2]

Sinai: rescue, covenant, and failure

At Sinai, God does not begin by demanding that slaves earn deliverance. He first rescues Israel from Egypt, then declares, "I am the LORD thy God, which have brought thee out of the land of Egypt" (Exod. 20:2). Grace precedes law. The law defines the life of a redeemed people, and the tabernacle makes possible God's dwelling in their midst.

But the covenant also exposes the heart. Israel pledges obedience and almost immediately makes the golden calf. The wilderness generation dies in unbelief. Judges depicts repeated apostasy. Kings records the collapse of both kingdoms. The prophets prosecute a covenant lawsuit: idolatry, injustice, sexual immorality, violence, and trust in political power reveal that the covenant problem is not merely inadequate information. The people possess commandments, priests, sacrifices, festivals, and prophets; what they lack is a heart that steadily loves God.

Deuteronomy already anticipates the crisis and cure

Deuteronomy 30:6

"And the LORD thy God will circumcise thine heart, and the heart of thy seed, to love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, that thou mayest live."

King James Version (public domain).

Deuteronomy predicts both exile and restoration (Deut. 28-30). It also predicts the deeper miracle Jeremiah will later unfold: God must circumcise the heart. The future of the covenant therefore depends not merely on another external summons but on divine action within the human person. Jeremiah 31 echoes Deuteronomy's language of heart, Torah, return, blessing, and renewed covenant loyalty. [12][20]

Joshua's closing warning is equally sobering. When the people confidently promise service, Joshua answers, "Ye cannot serve the LORD: for he is an holy God" (Josh. 24:19). The statement is

not a denial of responsibility; it is an exposure of presumption. Left to themselves, the people will not sustain covenant faithfulness. Jeremiah's great promise answers precisely this inability.

David: the covenant needs a faithful king

The covenant with David promises a royal son, an enduring house, and a kingdom established by God (2 Sam. 7:8-16). Yet David's own sin and the failures of his heirs demonstrate that the kingdom requires a righteous son of David who will both represent the people and shepherd them faithfully. Jeremiah joins new-covenant hope to Davidic hope: God will raise up "David their king" (Jer. 30:9), a righteous Branch (23:5-6; 33:14-18), and a ruler who draws near to God (30:21). The new covenant is therefore not an abstract inward experience. It is administered by the promised king.

The Old Testament's built-in tension

God's promises are irrevocable, yet the people are covenant breakers. God's law is good, yet the heart resists it. Sacrifice offers real covenantal forgiveness, yet the blood of animals cannot finally cleanse the conscience. The kingdom is promised to David, yet David's house repeatedly fails. Jeremiah's answer is not that God lowers his holiness. God will provide a faithful mediator, a decisive forgiveness, and a transformed people.

2. Jeremiah in the Shadow of Jerusalem's Fall

Jeremiah ministered during the last decades of Judah's kingdom. Called in the thirteenth year of Josiah (Jer. 1:2), he preached through reform, political upheaval, Babylonian domination, siege, and exile. His lifetime saw the apparent collapse of the institutions by which God's covenant promises had been publicly embodied: David's throne, Jerusalem, the temple, the land, and national life.

This historical setting gives the new-covenant oracle its force. Jeremiah is not speaking to a society enjoying religious stability. He speaks while the old order is visibly dying. The temple sermon has denied that sacred architecture can shield persistent rebellion (Jer. 7). The broken pottery of chapter 19 symbolizes irreversible judgment. The yoke of Babylon in chapters 27-28 exposes false prophets promising quick relief. By chapter 32 the city is under siege and Jeremiah is imprisoned for announcing its fall.

Approximate date	Event	Covenant significance
c. 627 BCE	Jeremiah is called during Josiah's reign (Jer. 1:2).	The prophet is commissioned "to root out" and also "to build, and to plant."
609 BCE	Josiah dies; political instability deepens.	Reform without lasting heart change proves fragile.
605 BCE	Babylon becomes the dominant imperial power.	Jeremiah insists that judgment through Babylon is God's covenant discipline.
597 BCE	Jerusalem is captured; Jehoiachin and	The question becomes whether exile

Approximate date	Event	Covenant significance
	leading citizens are exiled.	has canceled God's promise.
588/587 BCE	During the final siege, Jeremiah buys a field at Anathoth (Jer. 32).	A legal purchase becomes a sign that houses and fields will again be possessed.
587/586 BCE	Jerusalem and the temple fall.	The curse of the broken covenant reaches its historical climax.
538 BCE onward	Exiles begin returning under Persian rule.	Historical restoration begins, but the full inward and eschatological promise remains open.
First century AD	Jesus speaks of the new covenant in his blood.	The promised covenant is inaugurated through the Messiah's death and resurrection.

The "Book of Consolation"

Jeremiah 30-33 is often called the Book of Consolation because its dominant note is restoration. The shift is startling. The prophet best known for tears and judgment now announces healing, return, joy, rebuilding, renewed agriculture, restored worship, Davidic rule, and a permanent covenant. The arrangement itself preaches: judgment is not God's final word.

Jeremiah's original commission contained six verbs: to root out, pull down, destroy, overthrow, build, and plant (Jer. 1:10). The first four dominate much of the book. In Jeremiah 30-33, the last two finally sound with full power. God who watched over his people "to pluck up" will now watch over them "to build, and to plant" (31:28). The same sovereign vigilance that made judgment certain now guarantees restoration.

Movement in Jeremiah 30-33	Representative texts	Contribution to the new-covenant vision
Return and healing	30:3, 17-22	Exile will be reversed; God will restore health and covenant fellowship.
New exodus and joy	31:2-14	God gathers the scattered as a shepherd and leads them beside rivers.
Grief transformed	31:15-22	Rachel's weeping is answered with hope and return.
Heart-level covenant	31:27-34	Individual responsibility, internal Torah, universal knowledge, forgiveness.
Cosmic guarantee	31:35-37	Israel's continued identity is tied to the fixed order of creation.
Rebuilt holy city	31:38-40	Even formerly defiled spaces are incorporated into a city holy to the LORD.

Movement in Jeremiah 30-33	Representative texts	Contribution to the new-covenant vision
Field purchase under siege	32:1-35	Jeremiah enacts hope while Babylon's army surrounds the city.
Everlasting covenant	32:36-44	One heart, one way, enduring fear, divine delight, restored land.
Davidic and priestly promises	33:14-26	The covenant future includes righteous kingship, worship, and creation-like certainty.

3. Jeremiah 31:31-34: The Promise Line by Line

Jeremiah 31:31-34

31 Behold, the days come, saith the LORD, that I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel, and with the house of Judah:

32 Not according to the covenant that I made with their fathers in the day that I took them by the hand to bring them out of Egypt; which my covenant they brake, although I was an husband unto them, saith the LORD:

33 But this shall be the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel; After those days, saith the LORD, I will put my law in their inward parts, and write it in their hearts; and will be their God, and they shall be my people.

34 And they shall teach no more every man his neighbour, and every man his brother, saying, Know the LORD: for they shall all know me, from the least of them unto the greatest of them, saith the LORD: for I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more.

King James Version (public domain).

Verse 31: “Behold, the days come”

The prophetic formula directs the reader beyond the immediate catastrophe. Jeremiah is not merely predicting a better policy or a revived monarchy. “The days” belong to the book’s horizon of divine reversal: return from exile, Davidic rule, inward renewal, forgiveness, and permanent dwelling with God.

The New Testament later uses “last days” language for the era inaugurated by Jesus (Acts 2:16-17; Heb. 1:1-2). This does not mean every promise is exhausted immediately. Biblical fulfillment is often inaugurated before it is consummated. The resurrection of Jesus begins the general resurrection; the Spirit is the firstfruits of final renewal; the church tastes the powers of the age to come while still awaiting the complete removal of sin and death.

“I will make a new covenant”

The Hebrew phrase *berit chadashah*, “new covenant,” occurs explicitly only here in the Hebrew Bible, though equivalent promises appear elsewhere under terms such as “everlasting covenant” and “covenant of peace.” [17][19] The adjective “new” can carry the sense of new in quality, freshly established, or renewed. The context decides the substance of the newness.

Jeremiah does not present the covenant as a human religious reform. God is the repeated subject: “I will make,” “I will put,” “I will write,” “I will be,” “I will forgive,” “I will remember no more.” The grammar of the passage is the grammar of sovereign grace. The promised people respond, know, fear, and obey, but the decisive action begins with God.

“With the house of Israel, and with the house of Judah”

The divided kingdom is named in both halves. The northern kingdom had fallen to Assyria more than a century earlier; Judah now approached the same fate under Babylon. The promise therefore includes reunification. God will not merely preserve a Judean remnant. He will heal the fracture within the covenant people.

This wording must not be erased when Christians read the passage. The covenant is promised within Israel’s history, to Israel and Judah, by Israel’s God. The New Testament’s inclusion of Gentiles occurs through Israel’s Messiah and Israel’s promises, not through contempt for Israel. Paul’s olive-tree image warns Gentile believers against boasting: they are grafted into a root they did not create (Rom. 11:17-24).

The major Christian disagreement concerns how the original address continues to operate. Some interpreters see believing Jews and Gentiles together as the eschatological Israel in Christ. Others insist that the church’s participation does not exhaust a future national restoration of Israel. A responsible reading should state the disagreement while preserving two truths: the text names Israel and Judah, and the New Testament directly applies its blessings to the community gathered around Jesus.

Verse 32: “Not according to the covenant... when I took them by the hand”

The explicit comparison is with the exodus-Sinai covenant. God took Israel by the hand like a parent leading a child or a husband guiding his bride. The image is tender before it is judicial. The covenant began in deliverance: God heard groaning, remembered his promise, defeated Egypt’s gods, passed over Israel through sacrificial blood, and brought the people to himself.

“Not according to” signals real discontinuity. The new covenant cannot be reduced to another cycle of Sinai after national repentance. Yet the discontinuity is not total. The same God acts, the same moral holiness remains, the same covenant formula returns, and the goal is still a people who know, love, and obey the LORD. Jerry Hwang therefore emphasizes that Torah remains God’s instruction; the change is its effective inscription within the heart and the decisive forgiveness that enables covenant knowledge. [17]

“Which my covenant they brake”

Jeremiah identifies the failure without blaming God’s faithfulness. The covenant was broken by the people. Hebrews makes the same point when it introduces the quotation by saying that God “findeth fault with them” (Heb. 8:8). The law can command but cannot, by external command alone, create the heart it requires.

This helps avoid a common caricature. The old covenant was not evil, graceless, or mistaken. It revealed God, ordered Israel’s worship and life, restrained sin, exposed transgression, provided typological sacrifices, and carried the messianic promise. Its weakness lay in the sinful people and in its provisional institutions. The repeated sacrifices could cleanse ceremonially and restore covenant fellowship, but their repetition showed that they were not the final answer to guilt and conscience (Heb. 10:1-4).

“Although I was an husband unto them” - and the Greek wording

The traditional Hebrew reading can be translated “though I was a husband to them” or “though I was their master.” It highlights Israel’s betrayal of a faithful covenant Lord. The ancient Greek translation uses wording that can be rendered “I disregarded them” or “I ceased to care for them,” and Hebrews 8 follows that Greek form. The two readings emphasize different sides of the same covenant judgment: Israel violated a marriage-like bond, and God consequently handed the people over to judgment.

The textual difference is worth noticing because Hebrews does not hide its use of the Greek Scriptures. It is not evidence that the author invented a new passage. The substance of Jeremiah’s argument remains: the people did not continue in the covenant, and covenant judgment followed. [9][10][11]

Verse 33: “I will put my law in their inward parts”

The Hebrew torah means instruction and can refer broadly to God’s revealed will. Jeremiah does not say, “I will remove holiness from their concern.” He says God’s instruction will move from an external witness standing over against the sinner to an inwardly embraced reality. The contrast is not simply written law versus no law, but law resisted versus instruction loved.

Jeremiah 17:1 has already described Judah’s sin as engraved on the tablet of the heart. Jeremiah 31 answers engraving with engraving. God does not merely erase a bad record; he rewrites the inner person. The heart in biblical anthropology is not merely emotion. It is the center of thought, desire, will, memory, and moral direction. To write Torah there is to create a person whose deepest orientation bends toward God.

Law and grace

Jeremiah’s promise refuses the idea that grace and obedience are enemies. Grace does not merely cancel the consequences of rebellion while leaving rebellion enthroned. Grace forgives, teaches, transforms, and causes God’s people to walk in his ways. Ezekiel will state the same truth by joining a new heart, a new spirit, and the gift of God’s Spirit to Spirit-enabled obedience (Ezek. 36:26-27).

“I will write it in their hearts”

The image recalls the tablets written by the finger of God. Under the new covenant, God himself again writes, but the writing surface is human. Paul develops this contrast in 2 Corinthians 3: believers are a letter of Christ, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on stone tablets but on tablets of human hearts.

The image does not teach instant moral perfection. New Testament believers still require exhortation, correction, discipline, and growth. It teaches a decisive change of covenantal location and power: the Spirit creates genuine love for God, exposes and mortifies sin, produces fruit, and guarantees final completion. Christian sanctification is therefore neither self-salvation nor passivity. It is active obedience flowing from God’s prior inward work.

“I will be their God, and they shall be my people”

This is the covenant formula heard throughout Scripture (Gen. 17:7-8; Exod. 6:7; Lev. 26:12; Ezek. 36:28; 2 Cor. 6:16; Rev. 21:3). It reveals the goal behind every other blessing. Land, law, king, temple, sacrifice, and restoration serve communion with God.

The formula also prevents an individualistic reading. The law is written on individual hearts, but the result is a people. The new covenant creates a community whose shared identity is belonging to God. Personal regeneration and corporate membership belong together.

Verse 34: “They shall all know me”

To “know” the LORD is more than awareness that God exists. Jeremiah can equate knowing God with practicing justice and righteousness (Jer. 9:23-24; 22:15-16). Covenant knowledge is relational, moral, and saving.

The promise “they shall all know me” has generated major debates. It cannot mean the total abolition of teaching, because the New Testament appoints teachers and commands mutual instruction. Three complementary explanations are common:

First, the statement may be comparative and covenantal: no member will need the basic evangelistic summons “Know the LORD” in the sense of entering saving relationship, because all true members possess that knowledge. This reading is central to progressive covenantal and Reformed Baptist arguments for a regenerate new-covenant community. [3]

Second, it may be eschatological: the promise is genuinely inaugurated but reaches absolute form only in the consummation, when the redeemed see God fully and no false professor remains.

Third, it may stress immediacy of access. Under Israel’s former national structure, covenant life was heavily mediated through prophets, priests, kings, tribal identity, and household succession. In the new covenant, every believer has direct access to God through the one mediator, Jesus Christ, and receives the Spirit. Stephen Wellum emphasizes this structural transformation while still recognizing pastors and teachers as gifts to the church. [3][18]

“From the least... unto the greatest”

The promise cuts across hierarchy. Saving knowledge is not reserved for kings, priests, scribes, the wealthy, or the educated. The least and greatest stand on the same ground of mercy. Pentecost embodies this leveling grace: sons and daughters, young and old, servants and handmaids receive the Spirit (Joel 2:28-32; Acts 2:16-21).

“For I will forgive their iniquity”

The word “for” explains how universal covenant knowledge becomes possible. Forgiveness is not an appendix; it is the foundation. Sin alienates, blinds, condemns, and corrupts. God must remove guilt if the people are to know him.

Jeremiah’s promise goes beyond a vague willingness to overlook. In the canonical development, forgiveness is secured through the mediator’s sacrificial death. Hebrews places Jeremiah 31 around its central exposition of Christ’s priesthood and sacrifice. The new covenant is better because the mediator enters the heavenly sanctuary with his own blood, obtains eternal redemption, cleanses the conscience, and perfects his people by one offering (Heb. 9:11-15; 10:10-18).

“I will remember their sin no more”

God does not suffer memory loss. “Remember” is covenantal and judicial language. When God remembers a covenant, he acts according to it; when he remembers sin, he brings it into judgment. To remember sin no more means that forgiven sin will never again be charged against the covenant people as a condemning debt.

This promise supplies the believer’s assurance. Final acceptance rests not on the strength of human recollection, emotion, or performance but on God’s pledged non-imputation because Christ has borne the curse. The same God who knows every fact promises never to prosecute the pardoned sin again.

4. The Wider Frame of Jeremiah 31

Verses 27-30: responsibility and the sour-grapes proverb

Immediately before the new-covenant promise, Jeremiah rejects the proverb, “The fathers have eaten a sour grape, and the children’s teeth are set on edge” (31:29). The proverb had become a way of explaining exile that could slide into fatalism: the present generation suffered only for ancestral sins.

Jeremiah affirms individual responsibility without denying corporate consequences. Each person stands accountable before God. This prepares for the new covenant’s inward emphasis. The future people will not be held together merely by national descent and external administration. God will deal with the heart, and each covenant member will truly know him.

Verses 35-37: creation guarantees Israel's continuance

The oracle is followed by an oath grounded in the fixed order of sun, moon, stars, and sea. Only if that order ceases will Israel cease from being a nation before God. Then God declares that Israel's offspring would be rejected only if the heavens could be measured and the foundations of the earth searched out.

This placement matters. Christian interpretation must not turn the new covenant into a story of God discovering that Israel was a mistake. The covenant displays God's faithfulness to promises made within Israel's history. Darrell Bock and other dispensational or progressive dispensational scholars emphasize that these creation guarantees support a future for ethnic Israel and should not be absorbed into a purely ecclesial fulfillment. [23] Covenant theologians answer that God's faithfulness to Israel reaches its messianic goal in the faithful remnant, the Jewish Messiah, and the multinational people united to him, while Romans 11 still leaves room for a future large-scale turning of Jewish people to Christ. The debate concerns the form of fulfillment, not whether God is faithful.

Verses 38-40: a rebuilt and holy city

Jeremiah ends the chapter with geography. Towers, gates, measuring lines, the valley of dead bodies, and formerly unclean spaces are included in a city "holy unto the LORD." The promise is therefore embodied. God redeems people, places, worship, work, and public life.

The historical return under Persia begins this restoration, but it does not exhaust the language. The postexilic community continued to struggle with sin, foreign domination, and incomplete glory. Christian biblical theology sees the trajectory moving through Jesus, the true temple and Davidic king, toward the New Jerusalem where nothing unclean enters and the whole city becomes holy (Rev. 21-22).

5. Jeremiah 32: The Field, the Siege, and the Everlasting Covenant

Jeremiah 32 turns theology into a deed. The Babylonian army surrounds Jerusalem. Jeremiah is confined in the court of the guard because he has publicly announced that the city will fall. At that moment, God tells him to buy a family field at Anathoth.

The transaction is carefully legal: the right of redemption is invoked, money is weighed, the deed is signed and sealed, witnesses observe, and documents are placed in an earthen vessel for long preservation (32:6-15). The purchase is economically absurd if Babylon has the final word. It is rational only if God will restore ordinary life: "Houses and fields and vineyards shall be possessed again in this land" (32:15).

The field as enacted hope

Biblical hope is not denial. Jeremiah does not pretend the siege will disappear. He has spent years declaring that the city will fall. His purchase holds judgment and promise together: Babylon will win, and Babylon will not have the last word.

The field also reconnects redemption to land, inheritance, and kinship. The legal act echoes Levitical provisions that kept ancestral land within the family. Jeremiah becomes a sign that the inheritance is not permanently lost. The sealed deed waits like a promise buried in clay.

Jeremiah's prayer and God's answer

After buying the field, Jeremiah prays. He confesses God as Creator, covenant keeper, exodus deliverer, and judge who sees every human way (32:16-25). Yet his prayer ends in perplexity: the city is being given to the Chaldeans, and still God commanded him to buy a field.

God's answer begins with a question: "Behold, I am the LORD, the God of all flesh: is there any thing too hard for me?" (32:27). The answer first reaffirms judgment. The city truly will fall because of entrenched idolatry and child sacrifice. Only then does God unfold the restoration promise. Grace does not minimize evil; it overcomes evil after naming it truthfully.

Jeremiah 32:36-41

36 And now therefore thus saith the LORD, the God of Israel, concerning this city, whereof ye say, It shall be delivered into the hand of the king of Babylon by the sword, and by the famine, and by the pestilence;

37 Behold, I will gather them out of all countries, whither I have driven them in mine anger, and in my fury, and in great wrath; and I will bring them again unto this place, and I will cause them to dwell safely:

38 And they shall be my people, and I will be their God:

39 And I will give them one heart, and one way, that they may fear me for ever, for the good of them, and of their children after them:

40 And I will make an everlasting covenant with them, that I will not turn away from them, to do them good; but I will put my fear in their hearts, that they shall not depart from me.

41 Yea, I will rejoice over them to do them good, and I will plant them in this land assuredly with my whole heart and with my whole soul.

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Verse 37: gathering after judgment

God says both "I have driven them" and "I will gather them." Exile is not merely Babylonian geopolitics; it is covenant judgment under divine sovereignty. Restoration is equally divine. The same God who scattered will gather.

The promise has an immediate horizon in return from Babylon, a messianic horizon in Jesus gathering the lost sheep and forming one flock, and an eschatological horizon in the final gathering of God's people from every nation. These horizons should not be collapsed, but neither should they be severed. Historical return becomes a pattern and pledge of deeper redemption.

Verse 39: “one heart, and one way”

Jeremiah 31 speaks of the law written on hearts; Jeremiah 32 speaks of one heart and one way. The new covenant heals both inward division and communal fragmentation. A people divided between God and idols receives a unified moral center. A nation split into Israel and Judah receives a shared path.

“One way” is not bland uniformity of personality or culture. It is a common direction of worship and life. The New Testament describes the church as one body with many members, one Spirit, one hope, one Lord, one faith, and one baptism (Eph. 4:4-6). Unity arises from common participation in Christ, not from erasing difference.

“That they may fear me for ever”

The fear of the LORD is not servile terror alone. It is reverent awe, covenant loyalty, moral seriousness, and glad submission to God’s holiness. Jeremiah joins fear to “the good of them.” God’s commands are not arbitrary restrictions on flourishing; they direct his people toward life.

The phrase also answers cheap accounts of grace. The new covenant does not remove the fear of God. It implants it. Forgiveness and reverence increase together because the forgiven person sees both the horror of sin and the costliness of mercy.

Verse 40: the everlasting covenant and perseverance

Jeremiah 32 makes explicit what Jeremiah 31 implies: this covenant endures. God promises two corresponding actions. He will not turn away from doing good to his people, and he will put his fear in their hearts so that they will not turn away from him.

Divine preservation and human perseverance are not competitors. God preserves his people by creating and sustaining persevering faith, reverence, repentance, and obedience. This verse has therefore played an important role in Reformed teaching on perseverance. The promise is stronger than a bare offer. God undertakes to maintain the relationship from both sides: his beneficent purpose will not fail, and his inward work will keep his people from final apostasy.

Verse 41: God rejoices with his whole heart and soul

One of the most astonishing lines in Jeremiah describes God rejoicing to do good to his people and planting them “with my whole heart and with my whole soul.” The wording accommodates infinite divine commitment to human language. The point is not that God possesses a physical heart or divided emotional parts. The point is totality: restoration is not reluctant.

This transforms the emotional atmosphere of the covenant. The God who judges covenant treachery is not eager to remain distant. He delights to restore, plant, bless, and dwell with his people. In the New Testament, this divine joy shines in the shepherd who rejoices over the recovered sheep, the father who runs toward the returning son, and the joy set before Christ as he endures the cross.

Verses 42-44: public restoration

The chapter ends with deeds, witnesses, money, and fields across Judah. The everlasting covenant does not evaporate creation. It renews life in the world: homes, agriculture, commerce, justice, families, worship, and community. Salvation is spiritual, but “spiritual” in Scripture means wrought by the Spirit, not unreal or disembodied.

The field at Anathoth therefore functions as a down payment on the future. Jeremiah cannot yet see restored vineyards, but he can hold a deed. Christians likewise possess the Spirit as earnest or down payment of the inheritance (Eph. 1:13-14) while awaiting the redemption of the body and renewal of creation.

6. Jeremiah 33: David, Priesthood, and Restored Worship

Jeremiah 33 continues the promise while Jeremiah remains confined. God again identifies himself as the one who makes and establishes. He promises healing, peace, cleansing from iniquity, restored joy, flocks, worship, and the righteous Branch of David.

The chapter prevents the reader from reducing new-covenant salvation to private spirituality. The covenant future includes public kingship and ordered worship. “David shall never want a man to sit upon the throne of the house of Israel,” and the Levitical priests are described with enduring language (33:17-18).

The righteous Branch

Jeremiah 23:5-6 and 33:14-16 identify the coming king as a righteous Branch from David. He executes judgment and righteousness, saves Judah, and bears the name “The LORD our righteousness.” The new covenant requires this king because the people need more than inward inspiration: they need a representative who obeys where Adam, Israel, and David’s sons failed.

Jesus fulfills this royal hope as Son of David. His kingship is displayed paradoxically at the cross, vindicated in resurrection, and enthroned in ascension. The covenant is “in his blood” because the king saves by becoming the sacrifice.

Priesthood transformed and fulfilled

Christian interpreters differ over how Jeremiah’s priestly promise is fulfilled. Some expect a future earthly expression connected with restored Israel. Others read the language typologically: the Levitical priesthood reaches its goal in Christ’s superior, everlasting priesthood and in the priestly people united to him.

Hebrews argues that a change of priesthood entails a change in covenantal administration (Heb. 7:11-22). Jesus is not a Levitical priest but a priest after the order of Melchizedek. He does not deny the purpose of the Levitical system; he accomplishes what it prefigured. The endless succession of mortal priests gives way to one indestructible life and one sufficient sacrifice.

Jeremiah 31-33 as a unified promise

Jeremiah 31 supplies the famous vocabulary: new covenant, law on the heart, knowledge of God, forgiveness. Jeremiah 32 supplies permanence: one heart, one way, fear within, everlasting covenant, divine joy. Jeremiah 33 supplies royal and priestly shape: the righteous Davidic Branch and restored worship. Together they anticipate prophet, priest, king, sacrifice, Spirit, people, land, city, and presence.

7. The Prophetic Symphony

Jeremiah gives the only explicit Old Testament phrase “new covenant,” but the reality is woven through the Law and Prophets. Peter Gentry and Stephen Wellum argue that Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel mutually clarify the promise: Isaiah supplies servant, sacrificial, and international dimensions; Jeremiah emphasizes forgiveness and internal Torah; Ezekiel makes the role of the Spirit and new heart unmistakable. [3]

Text	Promise	Connection to Jeremiah 31-32
Deut. 30:1-10	Return from exile; heart circumcision; renewed love and obedience.	The covenant problem is solved by God’s work in the heart.
Isa. 42:6; 49:6-8	The Servant is given as a covenant and light to the nations.	The covenant is embodied in a person and extends blessing beyond Israel.
Isa. 53:4-12	The Servant bears sin and justifies many.	Explains the sacrificial basis of “I will forgive.”
Isa. 54:10; 55:3	Covenant of peace; everlasting covenant linked to Davidic mercies.	Joins permanent mercy to Davidic promise.
Isa. 59:20-21	Redeemer comes to Zion; Spirit and word remain with the people.	Paul later cites this in Romans 11 alongside forgiveness.
Ezek. 11:19-20	One heart, new spirit, heart of flesh.	Closely parallels Jeremiah 32:39.
Ezek. 36:24-28	Gathering, cleansing, new heart, Spirit, obedience, land, covenant formula.	Expands how Torah is written within.
Ezek. 37:21-28	One people, one Davidic shepherd, covenant of peace, everlasting sanctuary.	Parallels Israel-Judah reunion, Davidic king, everlasting covenant.
Hos. 2:14-23	Unfaithful bride wooed, restored, and betrothed forever.	Develops Jeremiah’s husband-and-bride covenant imagery.
Joel 2:28-32	Spirit poured out on all kinds of people.	Fulfills “least to greatest” access and inward empowerment.
Zech. 9:14	Humble king, pierced one, cleansing fountain, shepherd, universal kingship.	Links messianic suffering, cleansing, and kingdom.

Isaiah: the Servant as covenant

Isaiah does more than announce a covenant; he identifies the Servant as one “given for a covenant of the people” (Isa. 42:6; 49:8). This is a decisive advance. The covenant future is

concentrated in a representative person. The Servant restores Jacob and becomes a light to the Gentiles, carrying salvation to the ends of the earth (49:5-6).

Isaiah 53 then explains how forgiveness can be both merciful and just. The Servant bears griefs, is wounded for transgressions, carries iniquity, makes his soul an offering for sin, and justifies many. Jeremiah promises that God will remember sin no more; Isaiah shows sin being remembered against the substitute.

Ezekiel: new heart, new Spirit, new sanctuary

Ezekiel 36:26-27

“A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you... And I will put my spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes.”

King James Version (public domain).

Ezekiel states explicitly what Jeremiah’s heart-writing implies: God gives his Spirit. Cleansing, regeneration, indwelling, and obedience form one saving work. The Spirit does not merely enhance natural ability; he replaces the heart of stone with a heart of flesh.

Ezekiel 37 adds resurrection imagery, reunion of the divided people, one Davidic shepherd, an everlasting covenant of peace, and God’s sanctuary in their midst forever. Jeremiah and Ezekiel therefore converge on the same structure: return, inner transformation, faithful king, permanent covenant, and divine presence.

Hosea and the restored marriage

Jeremiah’s “husband” language belongs to a wider prophetic portrayal of idolatry as adultery. Hosea dramatizes the horror and mercy of that relationship. God judges the unfaithful bride, then woos her, speaks tenderly, restores fruitfulness, and betroths her forever in righteousness, judgment, lovingkindness, mercy, and faithfulness (Hos. 2:14-23).

Jesus’ self-identification as bridegroom and the New Testament’s marriage imagery for Christ and the church should be read against this background. The cross is covenant love pursuing an unfaithful people at infinite cost.

8. Jesus Announces the Covenant in His Blood

The Synoptic Gospels present Jesus’ final meal as the decisive covenant moment. Luke records: “This cup is the new testament in my blood, which is shed for you” (Luke 22:20). Paul preserves the same tradition in 1 Corinthians 11:25. The Greek word *diatheke* can mean covenant or testament; in this context it deliberately evokes Jeremiah’s new covenant.

Jesus does not merely say that his teaching is a new covenant. He identifies the covenant with his blood. The promise of inward law and forgiveness rests on a sacrificial death.

Passover, Exodus 24, and Jeremiah 31 meet at one table

The meal occurs in Passover context, recalling deliverance from Egypt by blood. Jesus' words "blood of the covenant" echo Moses at Sinai: "Behold the blood of the covenant" (Exod. 24:8). The adjective "new" recalls Jeremiah. The Last Supper therefore gathers three great biblical moments:

Passover: rescue from slavery and judgment.

Sinai: covenant ratified by blood.

Jeremiah: a promised covenant characterized by forgiveness and inward transformation.

Jesus places himself at the center of all three. He is the Passover Lamb, the mediator greater than Moses, and the one whose death inaugurates Jeremiah's promised future.

The faithful covenant keeper

The new covenant is unbreakable not because human seriousness suddenly becomes sufficient but because Jesus fulfills covenant obedience as the faithful representative. Where Adam grasped, Jesus humbled himself. Where Israel tested God in the wilderness, Jesus trusted the Father. Where Davidic kings exploited power, Jesus served. Where priests offered repeated sacrifices for others and themselves, Jesus offered his sinless self once for all.

Believers receive the covenant blessings by union with him. His righteousness becomes the ground of acceptance; his death bears the curse; his resurrection begins new creation; his Spirit writes the law within; his intercession secures perseverance.

Pentecost: the covenant gift poured out

At Pentecost, Peter identifies the Spirit's outpouring with Joel's last-days promise (Acts 2:16-21). The Spirit comes upon men and women, young and old, and servants. This does not replace Jeremiah; it explains the power by which Jeremiah is fulfilled.

Peter's sermon also holds Israel and the nations together. He speaks to Israelites, announces Jesus as Davidic Lord and Christ, calls for repentance and baptism, and says the promise is for "you, and to your children, and to all that are afar off" whom the Lord calls (Acts 2:39). The Abrahamic worldwide promise, Israel's prophetic hope, and the new-covenant Spirit converge in the risen Messiah.

Paul: letter, Spirit, and heart

In 2 Corinthians 3, Paul explicitly calls himself a minister of the new covenant. His contrast between letter and Spirit has sometimes been misread as written Scripture versus spiritual spontaneity. In context it contrasts the Mosaic covenant engraved on stone, glorious yet condemning in the face of sin, with the surpassing ministry of the Spirit who gives life and transforms believers into Christ's image.

The same apostle insists that the righteous requirement of the law is fulfilled in those who walk according to the Spirit (Rom. 8:1-4). New-covenant grace therefore neither legalizes self-salvation nor licenses lawlessness. It creates Spirit-enabled conformity to Christ.

Romans 11: Israel, forgiveness, and the future

Romans 11 combines prophetic language from Isaiah with the covenantal forgiveness theme: “This is my covenant unto them, when I shall take away their sins” (Rom. 11:27). Paul insists that God has not rejected his people, points to a present Jewish remnant chosen by grace, warns Gentiles against arrogance, and anticipates a future saving mystery concerning Israel.

Christians differ over whether “all Israel shall be saved” refers to the total elect people of God, a future large-scale conversion of ethnic Israel, or another nuanced combination. The passage at minimum forbids triumphalism. Gentile believers stand only by faith, depend on Israel’s Messiah and Scriptures, and should long for Jewish salvation rather than boasting over broken branches.

9. Hebrews 8-10: The Inspired Commentary on Jeremiah

Hebrews gives Jeremiah 31:31-34 unmatched prominence. Hebrews 8:8-12 reproduces the entire oracle, making it the longest continuous Old Testament quotation in the New Testament. Hebrews 10:16-17 quotes its heart-writing and forgiveness clauses again. The citation frames the central argument about Christ’s priesthood, sacrifice, and access to God. [9][10][11]

The author’s logic is not that Jesus happens to resemble Jeremiah’s hope. Jeremiah’s promise proves that the first covenantal administration was provisional. By calling another covenant “new,” Scripture itself made the former old and moving toward obsolescence (Heb. 8:13).

A better mediator and better promises

Hebrews 8:6 says Christ has obtained a more excellent ministry and mediates a better covenant established on better promises. “Better” does not mean the old covenant contained no grace or truth. It means the new covenant accomplishes in final form what the old foreshadowed:

The mediator is the eternal Son rather than a mortal servant.

The priesthood is indestructible rather than successive.

The sanctuary is heavenly reality rather than earthly copy.

The sacrifice is Christ himself rather than repeated animal offerings.

The cleansing reaches conscience rather than ceremonial status alone.

The access is confident and direct rather than restricted by veils.

The inheritance is eternal rather than typologically bounded.

The covenant creates the inward knowledge and forgiveness Jeremiah promised.

“He findeth fault with them”

Hebrews carefully locates the fault. The problem is not divine incompetence. God finds fault “with them” because they did not continue in the covenant (Heb. 8:8-9). The first covenant could command, warn, symbolize, and condemn, but it did not guarantee the universal saving knowledge of every covenant member.

This line is crucial in current debates. Progressive covenantal scholars argue that the new covenant's nature requires a regenerate membership in a way the old national covenant did not. Reformed paedobaptist theologians respond that the visible church can still contain covenant breakers and that warning passages in Hebrews address genuine members of the visible covenant community. Both sides agree that the saving substance belongs only to those united to Christ; they differ over how visible administration relates to that substance.

Hebrews 9: death, redemption, and inheritance

Hebrews 9:15 calls Christ “the mediator of the new testament” so that, by means of death, those called may receive the promise of eternal inheritance. The verse ties covenant, sacrifice, redemption, and inheritance together.

The death reaches backward as well as forward: it redeems transgressions committed under the first covenant. Old Testament saints were not saved by animal blood as an independent mechanism. They were forgiven through the divinely appointed shadows whose efficacy rested ultimately on Christ's future sacrifice. The cross is the center of covenant history.

Hebrews 10: the decisive logic of forgiveness

Hebrews 10 contrasts repeated sacrifices with Christ's once-for-all offering. Priests stand daily because their work is never finished; Christ sits because his sacrificial work is complete. Then the Holy Spirit bears witness by quoting Jeremiah: law written on heart and sins remembered no more.

The conclusion is explicit: “Now where remission of these is, there is no more offering for sin” (Heb. 10:18). Jeremiah's promise of non-remembrance means the sacrificial repetition has reached its goal. To return to the old system as though Christ had not come would deny the finality to which the system pointed.

Access, assurance, and warning

Hebrews applies the covenant in two directions. First, believers may draw near with a true heart in full assurance because Christ's blood opens the way and cleanses the conscience (10:19-22). Second, the same privileges intensify the danger of deliberate rejection (10:26-31). Grace produces assurance, not complacency.

The warning passages have generated difficult questions about apostasy and perseverance. Whatever position one adopts, Hebrews does not permit a shallow “once prayed, always safe” presumption. The new-covenant people are marked by enduring faith, mutual exhortation, holiness, and refusal to abandon Christ. Jeremiah 32 supplies the divine side of the same reality: God puts his fear within his people so that they do not finally turn away.

Hebrews 13:20 - the blood of the everlasting covenant

The letter closes by calling God “the God of peace, that brought again from the dead our Lord Jesus... through the blood of the everlasting covenant” (Heb. 13:20). This line joins resurrection to Jeremiah 32. The covenant is everlasting because the shepherd lives forever, his blood has accomplished redemption, and God equips his people to do his will.

The benediction's prayer is itself new-covenant language: God works in believers "that which is wellpleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ" (13:21). God's inward work produces the obedience he commands.

10. Major Christian Scholarly Views

The principal Christian traditions agree on the center: Jeremiah promised a decisive covenantal act of God; Jesus identifies his death as its inauguration; Hebrews declares Christ its mediator and sacrifice; the Spirit internalizes God's will; forgiveness is final in Christ. The disagreements concern structure, membership, Israel, land, sacraments, and fulfillment chronology.

Walter Kaiser: promise, continuity, and Israel

Walter C. Kaiser Jr.'s classic essay, "The Old Promise and the New Covenant," sought a mediating evangelical approach between covenantal and dispensational systems. He emphasizes that the new covenant grows from the older Abrahamic promise rather than canceling it, and he resists readings that detach the passage from the named houses of Israel and Judah. He also sees Christian participation in the promised blessings without treating that participation as proof that Israel's national hope has vanished. [2]

Kaiser's strength is his insistence that authorial intent and immediate context matter. Jeremiah 31:35-40 and chapters 32-33 attach the new covenant to restoration, land, city, Davidic hope, and Israel's continued identity. Critics ask whether his continuity model adequately accounts for Hebrews' strong language of obsolescence and the transformed nature of the covenant community.

O. Palmer Robertson and classic Reformed covenant theology

O. Palmer Robertson defines covenant as a bond in blood sovereignly administered and reads the biblical covenants as organically unified in God's redemptive purpose. In this tradition, the new covenant is the final and fullest administration of the one covenant of grace. The Mosaic administration becomes obsolete, but the Abrahamic promise and covenantal inclusion of believers and their children are seen as continuing unless expressly revoked. [4]

This view strongly emphasizes one people of God across history, continuity of the moral law, covenant signs, and the church as heir of Israel's promises in Christ. Its paedobaptist representatives argue that Jeremiah 31 describes the saving substance of the covenant rather than proving that every visible member is regenerate. Critics respond that "they shall all know me" and Hebrews' use of the passage point toward a new structure in which covenant membership and saving knowledge correspond more closely.

Peter Gentry and Stephen Wellum: progressive covenantalism

Gentry and Wellum present progressive covenantalism as a middle path between classic covenant theology and dispensationalism. They read each covenant in its own historical setting and then canonically in relation to Christ. The new covenant fulfills the previous covenants, but it is not merely another administration of the same covenantal structure. Jesus is the true seed, faithful Israel, Davidic king, and mediator in whom the covenant promises reach their goal. [3]

For this view, Jeremiah 31's "all shall know me" helps define the new-covenant community as regenerate. The church is constituted by those who confess faith and receive baptism as disciples. The tribal and genealogical structure of the old covenant gives way to a Christ-centered people entered through new birth and faith.

The view's strength is its attention to covenantal progression, Christological fulfillment, and the apparent universal saving knowledge in Jeremiah. Paedobaptist critics argue that it can understate continuity with Abraham and may make the visible church more purely regenerate than New Testament warning passages and church experience allow. Dispensational critics argue that it can absorb national and land promises too fully into Christ and the church.

Dispensational and progressive dispensational readings

Dispensational interpreters stress the grammatical address to Israel and Judah, the surrounding land promises, the creation oath of 31:35-37, and the Davidic-priestly promises of chapter 33. They typically hold that the new covenant is made with Israel and will reach a future national fulfillment, while differing over how the church participates now.

Older forms sometimes spoke as though there were separate new covenants or only analogous church blessings. Many contemporary dispensational and progressive dispensational scholars instead affirm one new covenant inaugurated by Christ, with the church participating in its spiritual blessings while a future fullness for Israel remains. Craig Blaising and Darrell Bock represent forms of this "already and not yet" approach. [18][23]

The strength of the view is its refusal to spiritualize the passage's Israelite and territorial context. Critics ask whether it divides the people of God too sharply or underestimates the New Testament's identification of Jew and Gentile as one new humanity in Christ.

G. K. Beale: inaugurated new creation

G. K. Beale places the new covenant within the larger biblical movement from creation to new creation. For Beale, the end-time restoration promised by the prophets has begun in Christ's death, resurrection, and gift of the Spirit. The church participates in Israel's restoration promises through union with the true Israelite Messiah, while consummation awaits Christ's return. [6]

This approach highlights temple, Spirit, resurrection, and worldwide mission. The law written on the heart belongs to the inaugurated new creation: believers are being transformed now and will be perfected later. Critics from more literal land-restoration models argue that this typological expansion can seem to relocate promises rather than fulfill them in their original form. Beale answers that New Testament fulfillment does not cancel the Old Testament pattern but escalates it in Christ and the new creation.

Thomas Schreiner: covenantal storyline centered in Christ

Thomas Schreiner traces the covenants as essential to Scripture's storyline while resisting the claim that "covenant" is the Bible's single center. The new covenant fulfills the promises through Jesus, secures forgiveness, and grants the Spirit. Schreiner's Baptist conclusions resemble progressive covenantalism, including the conviction that baptism ordinarily marks professing disciples rather than infants on the basis of genealogical succession. [5]

Schreiner's work is especially useful for holding together detailed exegesis and the broad sweep from creation to consummation. He also emphasizes the ethical goal of redemption: covenant grace creates a people who trust, love, and obey God.

F. F. Bruce, William Lane, Craig Koester, and Hebrews scholarship

Major Hebrews commentators such as F. F. Bruce, William Lane, and Craig Koester agree that Jeremiah's oracle is foundational to Hebrews' claim that Christ mediates a superior covenant. They emphasize the Greek form of Jeremiah used by Hebrews, the contrast between repeated earthly ritual and Christ's heavenly priestly work, and the decisive treatment of sin and conscience. [9][10] [11]

Their differences involve details of rhetoric, audience, warning, and the timing of the old covenant's disappearance. Together they show why Jeremiah 31 cannot be treated merely as a devotional metaphor. It structures the argument of Hebrews 8-10.

A Jewish interpretive caution

Jewish readings commonly understand Jeremiah as promising Israel's renewed covenant fidelity, internalized Torah, forgiveness, and restoration rather than replacement of Torah by Christianity. Alon Goshen-Gottstein's study shows that Jeremiah 31 has not held the same central place in Jewish interpretation that it holds in Christianity, though Jewish authors have often emphasized interiorization and personal appropriation. [19]

Christian interpretation should hear this caution. Jeremiah's "new" covenant is not anti-Jewish, and Jesus does not establish it by repudiating Israel's God or Scriptures. Christianity's claim is more specific and therefore more demanding: Israel's own Messiah fulfills Israel's own covenant hope, and Gentiles are included by grace. That claim should be argued from the texts with humility, not used as a warrant for contempt or coercion.

Question	Classic Reformed covenant theology	Progressive covenantal / Reformed Baptist	Dispensational / progressive dispensational
What becomes obsolete?	The Mosaic administration of the covenant of grace.	The Mosaic covenant as a distinct covenant; prior covenants reach fulfillment in Christ.	The Mosaic covenant; Abrahamic and Davidic national promises retain future dimensions.
Who is in the visible covenant community?	Believers and their children; saving benefits belong to the elect.	Professing regenerate disciples; baptism follows credible faith.	Church participants now; future Israel participates in national fulfillment.
What does "all know me" imply?	Describes saving substance and eschatological fullness, not necessarily every visible member.	Defines the covenant's new structure as regenerate in principle.	Will be fully realized in restored Israel, while church believers know God now.
How are land promises fulfilled?	Ultimately in Christ and the renewed creation; views differ on future Israel.	Typologically escalated in Christ and new creation.	Include a future earthly realization for national Israel.
Shared center	Jesus mediates the new covenant, forgives sin, gives the Spirit, and fulfills prophecy.	Jesus mediates the new covenant, forgives sin, gives the Spirit, and fulfills prophecy.	Jesus mediates the new covenant, forgives sin, gives the Spirit, and fulfills prophecy.

11. What Is Truly New? A Theological Synthesis

The adjective “new” should neither be weakened into “exactly the same” nor exaggerated into “unrelated to everything before.” The covenant is new through fulfillment and transformation. The following categories help state continuity and discontinuity precisely.

Not new	Truly new or climactically fulfilled
The identity of God: the LORD remains the God of Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Israel, and Jesus.	The Father is revealed climactically through the incarnate Son and poured-out Spirit.
The goal: “I will be their God, and they shall be my people.”	The goal is secured through permanent union with Christ and indwelling by the Spirit.
The moral holiness of God or the command to love God and neighbor.	God’s instruction is written within and fulfilled through Spirit-produced love.
The Abrahamic promise of offspring and worldwide blessing.	The promise reaches the nations through Abraham’s singular seed, Christ, and those united to him.
The Davidic promise of a king.	The king is the crucified, risen, and eternally enthroned Son of David.
The need for sacrifice, priesthood, cleansing, and mediation.	One priest offers himself once for all and opens permanent access.
The hope of land, city, temple, and divine presence.	These realities are escalated toward resurrection, worldwide inheritance, and New Jerusalem.
God’s concern for obedience.	Obedience becomes the fruit of regeneration rather than the basis of self-justification.
Forgiveness as an expression of divine mercy.	Forgiveness is secured by the completed sacrifice to which former sacrifices pointed.
A covenant people visible in history.	Jew and Gentile are formed into one new humanity around the Messiah and empowered by the Spirit.

New in mediator

Moses faithfully served in God’s house; Jesus is Son over the house (Heb. 3:1-6). The covenant’s permanence rests in the mediator’s identity. He is fully divine, fully human, sinless, resurrected, and eternally interceding.

New in sacrifice and forgiveness

The former sacrifices were God-given shadows. Christ is the reality. His sacrifice does not need repetition because the person offered is of infinite worth and the obedience rendered is complete. Jeremiah’s “remember no more” becomes possible because judgment has not been ignored; it has been borne.

New in internalization and Spirit

Old Testament believers experienced the Spirit and loved God's law. The newness is not that no one previously had inward faith. It is redemptive-historical fullness: the Spirit is poured out as the gift of the enthroned Messiah, the covenant community is defined around him, and the blessings promised for the last days are broadly distributed.

New in covenant membership and access

Every Christian tradition must account for Jeremiah's universal language. At minimum, saving participation in the new covenant belongs to those who know God through Christ. There is no hereditary, ethnic, clerical, or social class with privileged access to forgiveness. Every believer approaches the Father through the Son in one Spirit.

New in permanence

Jeremiah 32's everlasting covenant is secured from both directions: God will not cease doing good, and he will implant enduring fear so that his people do not finally leave. Hebrews grounds this permanence in Christ's indestructible life, completed offering, and constant intercession.

New in scope, without erasing Israel

The nations are not an afterthought. The Abrahamic promise always aimed at worldwide blessing, Isaiah's Servant becomes a light to the Gentiles, and Jeremiah's reunited people become the setting for universal knowledge of God. Yet Gentile inclusion should produce gratitude and humility, never the claim that Israel's Scriptures or history are disposable.

New in eschatological stage

The new covenant belongs to the last days. Its blessings are real now but not yet complete. Believers know God but still grow in knowledge. The law is written within but sin remains. Forgiveness is final but bodies still die. The Spirit indwells but creation still groans. This inaugurated-then-consummated structure explains why Jeremiah can be truly fulfilled in Christ while its absolute language still reaches toward the return of Christ and new creation.

The heart of the matter

God's answer to covenant failure is not a less demanding covenant. It is a better mediator, a final sacrifice, a stronger promise, an indwelling Spirit, an inwardly transformed people, and a forgiveness that can never again be prosecuted. The new covenant succeeds because God undertakes to do what human rebellion could not.

12. Living as the New-Covenant People

Assurance rooted in God's promise

The believer's assurance begins with "I will." God makes, writes, forgives, remembers no more, does good, and preserves. Faith looks away from its own instability to the mediator's sufficiency. This does not produce indifference to holiness; it produces the safety in which honest repentance becomes possible.

Obedience from the inside out

The written law on the heart means Christian ethics cannot be reduced to external conformity. Jesus exposes anger beneath murder, lust beneath adultery, hypocrisy beneath prayer, and greed beneath respectability. The Spirit aims at love from a pure heart, good conscience, and sincere faith.

Yet inwardness does not make outward action optional. Jeremiah repeatedly joins knowledge of God to justice for the poor, truthfulness, sexual fidelity, and rejection of idolatry. A heart written by God produces embodied obedience.

A worshiping and teaching community

"They shall teach no more" cannot be used against preaching, catechesis, scholarship, or parents instructing children. The apostles themselves teach constantly. The promise changes the purpose and ground of teaching: Christian teachers do not mediate saving access as though hearers cannot approach God except through an elite. They serve people who possess the Spirit, test teaching by Scripture, and are being led into truth.

Humility toward Israel and the Jewish people

Christians receive a covenant promised to Israel and Judah through Israel's Messiah. Anti-Judaism contradicts the very story Christians claim to believe. Paul commands Gentile believers not to boast but to fear, remember the root, and hope for mercy. Evangelism and theological disagreement must therefore be joined to love, historical honesty, and rejection of coercion or contempt.

The Lord's Supper as covenant remembrance

At the table, the church hears Jesus' words: the cup is the new covenant in his blood. The meal looks backward to the completed sacrifice, upward to communion with the risen Lord, outward to the one body, and forward until he comes. It is a recurring proclamation that forgiveness and fellowship were purchased, not achieved.

Mission to the nations

The least and greatest are invited to know the Lord. The new covenant therefore drives mission. The church does not spread a civilization's superiority but announces Israel's crucified and risen

Messiah, forgiveness of sins, the gift of the Spirit, and allegiance to the true king among every people and language.

Hope while the city is under siege

Jeremiah bought a field while siege ramps surrounded Jerusalem. New-covenant hope likewise acts before sight. Christians forgive because their sins are remembered no more. They pursue holiness because God writes his will within. They build communities of truth and mercy because God will renew creation. They bury the dead in hope because the shepherd was brought again from the dead through the blood of the everlasting covenant.

A final meditation

Jeremiah's world was collapsing. The temple stood but could not save hypocrites. The throne remained but could not produce a righteous king. The law was written but the heart was stone. Sacrifices continued but guilt returned. The land was inherited but exile approached.

Into that collapse God spoke in the first person: I will make. I will put. I will write. I will forgive. I will gather. I will give one heart. I will not turn away. I will rejoice to do good.

At the Last Supper, Jesus took the cup and declared that the promised future had arrived in his blood. At the cross, the covenant curse fell on the covenant keeper. In the resurrection, the shepherd of the everlasting covenant rose. At Pentecost, the Spirit began writing on human hearts. In the gospel, forgiveness is announced to Jew and Gentile. In the church, a people from least to greatest learn to know the Lord. At Christ's return, the unfinished dimensions will reach their fullness: sin gone, knowledge complete, Israel's God dwelling with a redeemed humanity in a renewed creation.

The new covenant is therefore the story of God's faithfulness when every human ground of confidence has failed. It is not merely a new religious arrangement. It is God's promise to create the people his holiness requires and his love desires - through Jesus Christ.

Appendices

Appendix A: A Canonical Verse Map

Theme	Foundational texts	New Testament fulfillment/use
Heart transformation	Deut. 10:16; 30:6; Jer. 24:7; 31:33; 32:39-40; Ezek. 11:19; 36:26-27	Rom. 2:28-29; 5:5; 8:1-14; 2 Cor. 3:3-6; Heb. 8:10; 10:16
Forgiveness	Jer. 31:34; 33:8; Isa. 53; Zech. 13:1	Matt. 26:28; Acts 2:38; Rom. 3:21-26; Heb. 9:11-15; 10:10-18
New/everlasting covenant	Jer. 31:31; 32:40; Isa. 55:3; 61:8; Ezek. 37:26	Luke 22:20; 1 Cor. 11:25; Heb. 8:6-13; 9:15; 12:24; 13:20
Knowing God	Jer. 9:23-24; 22:16; 31:34; Hos. 2:20	John 17:3; 1 Cor. 2:10-16; 1 John 2:20-27; Rev. 22:4
Spirit poured out	Isa. 32:15; 44:3; Ezek. 36:27; 39:29; Joel 2:28-32	Luke 24:49; Acts 2; Rom. 8; Gal. 3:14; Eph. 1:13-14

Theme	Foundational texts	New Testament fulfillment/use
Davidic king	2 Sam. 7; Isa. 9:6-7; 11:1-10; Jer. 23:5-6; 30:9; 33:14-17	Luke 1:32-33; Acts 2:25-36; Rom. 1:3-4; Rev. 5:5
Gathered people	Jer. 31:7-14; 32:37; Ezek. 37:21	John 10:16; 11:51-52; Eph. 2:11-22; Rev. 7:9-10
Divine presence	Lev. 26:11-12; Ezek. 37:27; Zech. 2:10-11	John 1:14; 14:16-23; 2 Cor. 6:16; Rev. 21:3
Land/new creation	Gen. 12; Deut. 30; Jer. 31:38-40; 32:41-44; Isa. 65-66	Matt. 5:5; Rom. 4:13; 8:18-25; Heb. 11:13-16; Rev. 21-22

Appendix B: Key Terms

Term	Meaning in this study
Covenant	A solemn relationship sovereignly established by God, involving promises, obligations, and covenantal signs or sanctions.
Berit chadashah	Hebrew for “new covenant” in Jeremiah 31:31.
Torah	Instruction; in context, God’s revealed will, not merely a narrow legal code.
Heart	The inner center of thought, desire, will, memory, and moral direction.
Know the LORD	Personal, covenantal, saving knowledge expressed in trust, worship, justice, and obedience.
Remember sin no more	A judicial promise never again to charge forgiven sin as a condemning debt.
Inaugurated eschatology	The promised last-days reality has truly begun in Christ but awaits complete consummation.
Typology	God-ordained historical patterns that reach escalated fulfillment in Christ and the new creation.
Regeneration	The Spirit’s life-giving work that creates a new heart and saving response to God.
Perseverance	The believer’s continuing faith and obedience, sustained by God’s preserving grace.
Supersessionism	A disputed term for views in which the church replaces or fulfills Israel; it must be defined carefully because it can describe very different claims.
New creation	The final renewal of embodied life and the world under God’s presence, begun in Christ’s resurrection.

Appendix C: Study and Discussion Questions

1. Why does Jeremiah contrast the new covenant specifically with the covenant made at the exodus?

2. What is the relationship between forgiveness in Jeremiah 31:34 and heart transformation in 31:33?
3. How does Jeremiah 32:40 deepen the promise of Jeremiah 31:31-34?
4. What does “they shall all know me” mean, and why can it not mean the abolition of Christian teaching?
5. How do Jeremiah 31:35-40 and 32:41-44 affect the debate over Israel and the land?
6. How does Isaiah’s Servant explain the sacrificial basis of Jeremiah’s forgiveness promise?
7. What does Ezekiel add to Jeremiah’s description of the law written on the heart?
8. Why does Jesus connect the covenant to his blood at Passover?
9. How does Hebrews use Jeremiah to explain the obsolescence of the old covenant?
10. What is the difference between saying the old covenant was evil and saying it was provisional?
11. How do divine preservation and human perseverance work together in Jeremiah 32:40?
12. Which aspects of the new covenant are already experienced, and which await consummation?
13. How should Gentile Christians speak about Israel in light of Romans 11?
14. What practices in church life express the reality of inward Torah, direct access, forgiveness, and one heart?
15. How does Jeremiah’s purchase of the field model faithful action during visible collapse?

Appendix D: Selected Scholarly Conclusions at a Glance

Scholar or tradition	Emphasis useful for reading Jeremiah 31-32
Walter C. Kaiser Jr.	Continuity of the Abrahamic promise, original address to Israel and Judah, and need to hold Christian participation together with Israel’s future.
O. Palmer Robertson	Organic unity of the covenants and the new covenant as climactic fulfillment of the covenant of grace.
Peter Gentry and Stephen Wellum	Progressive unfolding of distinct covenants, fulfillment in Christ, and a structurally regenerate new-covenant community.
G. K. Beale	Inaugurated new creation: prophetic restoration begins in Christ and the Spirit and culminates in the renewed cosmos.
Thomas Schreiner	Covenantal storyline centered in Jesus, with forgiveness and Spirit-enabled obedience.
F. F. Bruce / William Lane / Craig Koester	Hebrews reads Jeremiah as proof of Christ’s superior priesthood, final sacrifice, cleansed conscience, and better covenant.
Dispensational / progressive dispensational scholars	The Israel-Judah address, land, creation oath, and Davidic promises require a future fullness for ethnic Israel.
Jewish interpretation	Internalized Torah and renewed fidelity should not be casually equated with abolition of Torah or contempt for Israel.

Source Notes and Bibliography

Scripture quotations are from the King James Version, which is in the public domain. Verse references are supplied throughout. The following works were used for historical context, exegesis, canonical synthesis, and representation of major viewpoints.

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- [15] Philip Graham Ryken, *Jeremiah and Lamentations: From Sorrow to Hope, Preaching the Word* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2001).
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Recommended Further Reading by Level

Level	Recommended starting point	Why
Accessible	Thomas Schreiner, <i>Covenant and God’s Purpose for the World</i> ; Christopher Wright, <i>The Message of Jeremiah</i> .	Clear whole-Bible storyline and readable exposition.
Intermediate	O. Palmer Robertson, <i>The Christ of the Covenants</i> ; F. F. Bruce, <i>Hebrews</i> .	Classic covenant theology and strong evangelical Hebrews scholarship.
Advanced	Gentry and Wellum, <i>Kingdom through Covenant</i> ; Beale, <i>A New Testament Biblical Theology</i> ; Lane or Koester on <i>Hebrews</i> .	Detailed exegesis, canonical theology, and major interpretive debates.
Specialized	Kaiser’s JETS article; Adeyemi on Torah; Goshen-Gottstein on Jewish reception; Terblanche on transformation.	Focused study of disputed phrases, reception history, and scholarly arguments.

Closing confession

The God who promised the new covenant is the God who fulfills it. The Father sends the Son; the Son gives his blood; the Spirit writes upon the heart; the forgiven people know the Lord; and the covenant reaches its goal when God dwells with humanity in the renewed creation.